

YOGA

Comprehensive Philosophical Notes

Based on Chapter 10 of C.D. Sharma's *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

I. Introduction

Patañjali is the traditional founder of the Yoga system. The word 'Yoga' literally means 'union', i.e. spiritual union of the individual soul with the Universal Soul, and is used in this sense in the Vedānta. The Gītā defines Yoga as that state than which there is nothing higher or worth realizing, and firmly rooted in which a person is never shaken even by the greatest pain — that state, free from all pain and misery, is Yoga. According to Patañjali, however, Yoga does not mean union but **spiritual effort** to attain perfection through the control of the body, the senses, and the mind, and through right discrimination between Puruṣa and Prakṛti.

Yoga's Relation to Sāṅkhya

Yoga is intimately allied to Sāṅkhya. The Gītā calls them one. Yoga means spiritual action, and Sāṅkhya means knowledge: Sāṅkhya is theory, Yoga is practice. For all practical purposes, Sāṅkhya and Yoga may be treated as the theoretical and the practical sides of the same system. Yoga mostly accepts the metaphysics and the epistemology of Sāṅkhya. It shows the practical path by following which one may attain **Viveka-jñāna**, discriminative knowledge, which alone leads to liberation. Yoga accepts the three pramāṇas of Sāṅkhya — perception, inference, and testimony — and also the twenty-five metaphysical principles.

The one significant point of divergence is theological: Yoga believes in **God** as the highest Self, distinct from the other selves. Hence it is sometimes called 'Seśvara Sāṅkhya' or 'theistic Sāṅkhya', as distinct from classical Sāṅkhya, which is *nirīśvara*, or atheistic.

The Four Books of the Yoga-Sūtra

The Yoga-sūtra is divided into four parts:

Pāda (Book)	Subject Matter
Samādhi-pāda	The nature and aim of concentration
Sādhana-pāda	The means to realize this end
Vibhūti-pāda	The supra-normal powers which can be acquired through Yoga
Kaivalya-pāda	The nature of liberation and the reality of the transcendental self

II. Chitta and Its Vṛttis

Pātañjala Yoga is also known as **Rāja Yoga**. Yoga is defined as the **cessation of the modifications of chitta** (*yogaścittavṛttinirodhaḥ*). This cessation is achieved through meditation or concentration, which is itself also called Yoga (*yogaḥ samādhiḥ*).

What Chitta Is

Chitta means the three internal organs of Sāṅkhya — buddhi or intellect, ahaṅkāra or ego, and manas or mind. Chitta is the same as *antaḥkaraṇa*. It is Mahat or Buddhi, which includes ahaṅkāra and manas within it. Chitta is the first evolute of Prakṛti and has the predominance of Sattva. It is in itself unconscious. But being the finest evolute and nearest to Puruṣa, it has the power to reflect the Puruṣa, and therefore appears as if it is conscious.

When Chitta gets related to any object, it assumes the ‘form’ of that object. This form is called **Vṛtti**, or modification. The light of consciousness which comes from the Puruṣa and illuminates this ‘form’ is called ‘jñāna’. Puruṣa is essentially pure consciousness and is free from the limitations of Prakṛti. But it wrongly identifies itself with its reflection in the Chitta and thereby appears to undergo change and modification. Chitta, therefore, is the physical medium for the manifestation of the spirit.

The Two Analogies of Reflection

- Just as in a red-hot iron ball, formless fire appears spherical and cold iron appears hot, similarly, on account of its reflection in the Chitta, Puruṣa appears changing and Chitta appears conscious.
- Just as the moon appears as moving when seen reflected in moving waves, and the waves appear luminous, similarly Puruṣa appears as undergoing modifications, and Chitta appears as conscious, due to Puruṣa’s reflection in it.

When the Chitta realizes that it is completely isolated and is only a passive spectator, beyond the play of Prakṛti, it ceases to identify itself with its reflection in the Chitta — with the result that the light is withdrawn and the modifications of the Chitta fall to the ground. This cessation of the modifications of the Chitta through meditation is called ‘Yoga’. It is the return of the Puruṣa to its original perfection.

The Five Kinds of Vṛttis

The modifications of the Chitta are of five kinds: (1) right cognition (*pramāṇa*), (2) wrong cognition (*viparyaya*), (3) verbal cognition or imagination (*vikalpa*), (4) absence of cognition or sleep (*nidrā*), and (5) memory (*smṛti*).

Right cognition (pramāṇa) is itself of three kinds:

(a) Perception (pratyakṣa) — when the Chitta, through the sense-organs, comes into contact with the external object and assumes its form, or comes into contact with the internal mental state.

(b) Inference (anumāna) — when the Chitta cognizes the generic nature of things.

(c) Verbal testimony (śabda).

Viparyaya is positively wrong knowledge, like that of the rope-snake (mistaking a rope for a snake). **Vikalpa** is mere verbal cognition without a corresponding object, like that of the hare’s horn. **Nidrā** is called absence of cognition, and yet it is itself a mental modification — because after sleep a person says ‘I slept soundly and knew nothing’, and therefore there must be some mental modification present to support this very report of an absence of knowledge. **Smṛti** is the recollection of past experience through the impressions left behind by it.

Puruṣa, the Phenomenal Ego, and the Five Kleśas

In fact, the Puruṣa is the eternally pure and transcendental consciousness. It is the Chitta with the reflection of the Puruṣa in it — or the Puruṣa as reflected in the Chitta — which is the **phenomenal ego or Jīva**: it is this Jīva which is subject to birth and death and transmigration and to all painful or pleasurable experiences, and which imagines itself to be the agent and the enjoyer.

There are five kinds of sufferings (*kleśa*) to which the Jīva is subject:

1. **Ignorance** (*avidyā*)
2. **Egoism** (*asmitā*)
3. **Attachment** (*rāga*)
4. **Aversion** (*dveṣa*)
5. **Clinging to life and the instinctive fear of death** (*abhiniveśa*)

The bondage of the self is due to its wrong identification with the mental modifications. Liberation, therefore, means the end of this wrong identification through proper discrimination between Puruṣa and Prakṛti, and the consequent cessation of the mental modifications. It is the aim of Yoga to bring about this result.

The Five Levels of Mental Life (Cittabhūmi)

There are five levels of mental life. The differences among these levels are due to the predominance of the different Guṇas.

1. **Kṣipta** (restless) — the lowest level. The mind here is restless due to the excess of rajas and is tossed about, like a shuttlecock, between different sense-objects.
2. **Mūḍha** (torpid) — the mind here has the predominance of tamas and tends towards ignorance, sleep, and lethargy.
3. **Vikṣipta** (distracted) — here sattva predominates, but rajas also asserts itself at times. (*Note: Vikṣipta here does not mean 'extremely restless' as its name might suggest, but rather 'better than Kṣipta' — because in Kṣipta rajas predominates, while in Vikṣipta sattva predominates.*)
4. **Ekāgra** (concentrated) — the mind here is entirely dominated by sattva, and rajas and tamas are subdued. The mind becomes concentrated on the object of meditation.
5. **Niruddha** (restricted) — the fifth and highest level. Here the mental modifications are arrested, though their latent impressions remain.

The first three levels are not at all conducive to Yogic life. Only the last two are.

III. Aṣṭāṅga Yoga (The Eightfold Path)

Yoga advocates control over the body, the senses, and the mind. It does not want to kill the body; on the other hand, it recommends its perfection — a sound mind needs a sound body. Sensual attachment and passions distract the body as well as the mind; they must be conquered. To overcome them, Yoga gives us the Eightfold Path of Discipline (**Aṣṭāṅga Yoga**):

1-5: The External Aids (Bahiraṅga Sādhana)

1. Yama — abstention. It includes the five vows of Jainism: abstention from injury through thought, word, or deed (*ahiṃsā*), from falsehood (*satya*), from stealing (*asteya*), from passions and lust (*brahmacharya*), and from avarice (*aparigraha*).

2. Niyama — self-culture. It includes external and internal purification (*śauca*), contentment (*santoṣa*), austerity (*tapas*), study (*svādhyāya*), and devotion to God (*Īśvara-praṇidhāna*).

3. Āsana — steady and comfortable posture. There are various kinds of postures which are a physical help to meditation. This is the discipline of the body.

4. Prāṇāyāma — control of breath. It deals with the regulation of inhalation, retention, and exhalation of breath. It is beneficial to health and is highly conducive to the concentration of the mind. But it must be performed under expert guidance, otherwise it may have bad after-effects.

5. Pratyāhāra — control of the senses. It consists in withdrawing the senses from their objects. Our senses have a natural tendency to go outward to objects; they must be checked and directed towards the internal goal. It is the process of introversion.

These five are called external aids to Yoga (*bahiraṅga sādhana*), while the remaining three, which follow, are called internal aids (*antaraṅga sādhana*).

6-8: The Internal Aids (Antaraṅga Sādhana)

1. Dhāraṇā — fixing the mind on the object of meditation, like the tip of the nose, the mid-point of the eyebrows, the lotus of the heart, or the image of the deity. The mind must be steadfast, like the unflickering flame of a lamp.

2. Dhyāna — meditation. It means, and consists in, the undisturbed flow of thought around the object of meditation (*pratyayaikatānatā*). It is steadfast contemplation without any break.

3. Samādhi — concentration, the final step in Yoga. Here the mind is completely absorbed in the object of meditation. In dhyāna, the act of meditation and the object of meditation remain separate; but here they become one. It is the highest means to realize the cessation of mental modifications, which is the end. It is the ecstatic state in which the connection with the external world is broken, and through which one has to pass before obtaining liberation.

The Two Kinds of Samādhi

Samādhi is of two kinds: **conscious** or *samprajñāta*, and **supra-conscious** or *asamprajñāta*. In the former, consciousness of the object of meditation persists; in the latter, it is transcended. The former corresponds to the Ekāgra level of mental life; the latter to the Niruddha level.

Samprajñāta Samādhi and Its Four Kinds

In the conscious (*samprajñāta*) form, the mind remains concentrated on the object of meditation. The meditator and the object of meditation are fused together, yet the consciousness of the object of meditation persists. This state is said to be of four kinds:

(a) Savitarka — when the Chitta is concentrated on a gross object of meditation, like the tip of the nose or the mid-point of the eyebrows or the image of the deity.

(b) Savichāra — when the Chitta is concentrated on a subtler object of meditation, like the tanmātras.

(c) Sānanda — when the Chitta is concentrated on a still subtler object of meditation which produces joy, like the senses.

(d) Sāsmitā — when the Chitta is concentrated on the ego-substance with which the self is generally identified. Here we have conscious ecstasy where individuality persists.

Asamprajñāta Samādhi

Asamprajñāta Samādhi is that supra-conscious concentration where the meditator and the object of meditation are completely fused together, and there is not even consciousness of the object of meditation. Here no new mental modifications arise; they are checked (*niruddha*), though the latent impressions may continue.

The analogy given is this: if fire is restricted to a particular fuel, it burns that fuel alone; but when that fuel has been completely burnt, the fire also dies down. Similarly, in conscious concentration, the mind is fixed on the object of meditation alone, and modification arises only in respect of this object of meditation; but in supra-conscious concentration, even this modification ceases.

It is the highest form of Yoga — ‘divine madness’, a perfect mystic ecstasy, difficult to describe and even more difficult to attain. Even those who attain it cannot retain it for long. Immediately, or after a very short time, the body breaks and they obtain complete liberation.

Yoga generates certain supra-normal powers. But these should be avoided, and attention should be fixed only on liberation, which is the end of human life. The ideal is **Kaivalya** — the absolute independence and the eternal and free life of the Puruṣa, free from Prakṛti.

IV. God

Yoga accepts the existence of God. The interest of Patañjali himself in God seems to be practical, but the later Yogins have taken a theoretical interest in Him too, and have tried to prove His existence as a necessary philosophical speculation.

Patañjali's Definition of God

Patañjali defines God as a special kind of Puruṣa who is always free from pains, actions, effects, and impressions. He is eternally free and was never bound, nor has any possibility of being bound. He is above the law of Karma. He is omniscient, omnipotent, and omnipresent. He is perfection incarnate; He is purest knowledge. He is the teacher of the ṛṣis (*sa pūrveṣāmapī guruḥ* — ‘He is the teacher even of the ancients’) and the teacher of the Veda. ‘Aum’ is His symbol. Devotion to God is one of the surest means of obtaining concentration.

kleśakarmavipākāśayair aparāmṛṣṭaḥ puruṣaviśeṣa īśvaraḥ — Yoga-sūtra, I.24.

The Proofs Advanced for God's Existence

(a) The Veda tells us that God exists.

(b) The law of continuity tells us that there must be the highest limit of knowledge and perfection, which is God.

- (c) God is responsible for the association and dissociation of Puruṣa and Prakṛti.
- (d) Devotion to God is the surest way of obtaining concentration and thereby liberation.

The Limits of Yoga's God

But the God of Yoga is not the creator, preserver, or destroyer of this world. He is only a special Puruṣa. He does not reward or punish the souls. Innumerable Puruṣas and Prakṛti, all eternal and absolute, are there to limit Him. He cannot grant liberation; He can only remove the obstacles in the upward progress of the devotees. Directly, He has nothing to do with the bondage and the liberation of the Puruṣas — ignorance binds, and discrimination between Prakṛti and Puruṣa liberates. The end of human life is not union with God, but only the separation of Puruṣa from Prakṛti. Such a conception of God, Sharma observes, is certainly unsatisfactory.

Concluding Assessment

The Yoga system of Patañjali should not be confused with magic, tantra, and self-hypnotization. It is a great system of spiritual discipline, and has found favour with all schools of Indian philosophy except the Chārvāka. It is founded on the metaphysics of Sāṅkhya, and gives us a practical path of purification and self-control in order to realize the true nature of man.